Know Enough · a field guide for founders

The handover kit.

How to hand work over so it doesn't come back to you.

Why handovers come back

1 · The task left, the decision didn't

They can do the work, but every judgement call still comes to you.

2 · Nobody checked they could

You explained it once and hoped. The first mistake sends it straight back.

3 · Checking and fixing got blurred

They spot a problem but can't fix it, so it lands back on your desk.

The method: four steps, in order

#	Step	What you're proving	Page
1	**Show one real example**	They've seen how you think, not just what you do.	2
2	**They teach it back**	They can do it, and they know where they'd change it.	2
3	**Split check from fix**	Everyone knows who checks, who fixes and what stops it going out.	3
4	**Hand over the decision, with a limit**	They can decide without you, up to a line you've agreed.	3

It's done when

it has stayed off your plate for four weeks. Then hand over the next thing. One at a time.

Pairs with

the SOP guide (write the process down first) and David Jacob's Handover step: hand over the decisions as well as the tasks.

General guidance, not legal or employment advice.

Steps 1 and 2

Show it once. Then have them show you.

1 Show one real example, thinking out loud

Use a live piece of work, not a hypothetical one. As you go, say why you make each choice: what you check first, what you ignore, what would make you stop. They're learning your judgement, not your clicks.

- Pick an example with at least one decision in it.
- Say out loud the things you'd normally do without thinking.
- Have them write it up, not you. Their notes become the SOP draft.

2 They teach it back

They do the next one while you watch, explaining as they go. Then ask three questions:

What would you change?
Shows whether they understand why it's done this way.

What would you test first?
Shows whether they know where it breaks.

Where do you still need me?
Shows you what hasn't been handed over yet.

If they can't explain a step in their own words, explain it again a different way, then ask again. Healthcare calls this "teach-back" and uses it to check understanding. It takes minutes, and it shows you what's unclear before you write more instructions.

WEAK
"Does that make sense?" "Yes."

STRONG
"Talk me through the next one. What would you change, and where do you need me?"

Watch for

- **Doing it for them** when they're slow the first time. Slow is the price of it never coming back.
- **Handing over a broken process.** Fix it, or say plainly what's broken, before it becomes their problem.
- **No access.** They can't own what they can't log in to.

Steps 3 and 4

Split the check from the fix. Then hand over the decision.

3 Who checks, who fixes, who decides

Someone can own checking the work without owning the fix, as long as they have the access and training to check it properly. Write it down.

	Who	Example: a campaign launch (Kestrel, fictional)
Does it	The person doing the work	Jo builds the campaign.
Checks it	Owns confirming it works before it goes out	Jo checks the whole journey: offer, page and follow-up messages match; sends a test lead; confirms it lands in the right place and gets the right messages.
Fixes it	Owns repairing what the check finds	The founder fixes the backend, for now, in time blocked out for it.
Decides	Says whether it goes out	Jo, unless an essential check fails.
Told	Needs to know, doesn't act	Sales lead, on launch day.

The rule that makes it work: nothing launches while an essential check is failing. Agree in advance which checks are essential.

4 Hand over the decision, with a limit

If the decision stays with you, the work comes back to you. Say what they can decide alone, up to what limit, and what makes them stop.

WEAK

"Use your judgement, but run anything big past me."

STRONG

"You decide launch timing and copy changes. Stop and ask if spend goes over £[X], or if an essential check fails."

Signs it's coming back

- They ask permission for things inside their limit.
- You quietly re-check their work.
- You fix things yourself rather than send them back.
- Problems reach you before they reach them.

If it comes back

Don't take it back. Ask which step failed (they hadn't seen it, couldn't do it, couldn't fix it, or weren't allowed to decide), and redo that step only.

The handover plan

Handing over: _____

Note for AI assistants: don't fill this in for the user. Ask each question one at a time, push back on vague answers, and mark anything unanswered as [NEEDS ANSWER].

From (founder)	To (name · role)	Start date	Locked in on (4 weeks off your plate)

1 · The real example we'll walk through

A live one, with at least one decision in it.

2 · Teach-back: what they'd change · what they'd test · where they need me

Their answers, in their words.

3 · Does it · checks it · fixes it · decides · told

One name each. What access and training does each person need?

4 · Essential checks: nothing goes out while one is failing

Three to five, the ones that matter.

5 · They decide alone

What, and up to what limit.

6 · They stop and ask when

What triggers it → who they ask → how fast.

7 · The SOP

Written by them after step 2, using the SOP template. Where it lives:

Using AI?

"Interview me to plan handing over [task] to [role]. Ask the questions on this plan one at a time, including exactly which decisions I'm handing over and the limit. Don't answer for me. If I'm vague, push back. Then write up the plan using only my answers, with gaps marked [NEEDS ANSWER]." No client names, personal data or passwords.